

FEDERAL MARITIME COMMISSION
Office of Administrative Law Judges

GREATWAY LOGISTICS GROUP, LLC, *Complainant*

v.

OCEAN NETWORK EXPRESS PTE. LTD., *Respondent*.

DOCKET NO. 21-04

Served: November 30, 2021

ORDER OF: Erin M. WIRTH, *Chief Administrative Law Judge*.

INITIAL DECISION APPROVING SETTLEMENT AGREEMENT¹

On November 10, 2021, Complainant Greatway Logistics Group, LLC (“Greatway”) and Respondent Ocean Network Express Pte. Ltd. (“ONE”) filed a joint motion (“Motion”) seeking approval of a settlement agreement, dismissal of the complaint with prejudice, and treatment of the settlement agreement as confidential. A copy of the confidential settlement agreement was attached to the motion. On November 12, 2021, the Commission’s Bureau of Enforcement (“BOE”), which had intervened in the proceeding, filed a response to the motion.

Using language borrowed in part from the Administrative Procedure Act, Rule 75 of the Commission’s Rules of Practice and Procedure gives interested parties an opportunity, *inter alia*, to submit offers of settlement where “time, the nature of the proceeding, and the public interest permit.” 46 C.F.R. § 502.75(b); *see* 5 U.S.C. § 554(c). If dismissal is sought due to a settlement by the parties, “the settlement agreement must be submitted with the motion for determination as to whether the settlement appears to violate any law or policy and to ensure the settlement is free of fraud, duress, undue influence, mistake, or other defects which might make it unapprovable.” 46 C.F.R. § 502.72(a)(3). “Unless the order states otherwise, a dismissal under this paragraph is without prejudice.” 46 C.F.R. § 502.72(a)(3).

The Commission has a strong and consistent policy of “encourag[ing] settlements and engag[ing] in every presumption which favors a finding that they are fair, correct, and valid.” *Inlet Fish Producers, Inc. v. Sea-Land Serv., Inc.*, 29 S.R.R. 975, 978 (ALJ 2002) (quoting *Old Ben Coal Co. v. Sea-Land Serv., Inc.*, 18 S.R.R. 1085, 1091 (ALJ 1978) (*Old Ben Coal*)). *See also Ellenville Handle Works, Inc. v. Far Eastern Shipping Co.*, 20 S.R.R. 761, 762 (ALJ 1981).

The law favors the resolution of controversies and uncertainties through compromise and settlement rather than through litigation, and it is the policy of the law to uphold and enforce such contracts if they are fairly made and are not in contravention of some law or public policy. . . . The courts have considered it

¹ This initial decision will become the decision of the Commission in the absence of review by the Commission. 46 C.F.R. § 502.227.

their duty to encourage rather than to discourage parties in resorting to compromise as a mode of adjusting conflicting claims. . . . The desire to uphold compromises and settlements is based upon various advantages which they have over litigation. The resolution of controversies by means of compromise and settlement is generally faster and less expensive than litigation; it results in a saving of time for the parties, the lawyers, and the courts, and it is thus advantageous to judicial administration, and, in turn, to government as a whole. Moreover, the use of compromise and settlement is conducive to amicable and peaceful relations between the parties to a controversy.

Old Ben Coal, 18 S.R.R. at 1092 (quoting 15A AM. JUR. 2D *Compromise and Settlement* § 3 (1976)).

“While following these general principles, the Commission does not merely rubber stamp any proffered settlement, no matter how anxious the parties may be to terminate their litigation.” *Old Ben Coal*, 18 S.R.R. at 1092. However, if “a proffered settlement does not appear to violate any law or policy and is free of fraud, duress, undue influence, mistake or other defects which might make it unapprovable despite the strong policy of the law encouraging approval of settlements, the settlement will probably pass muster and receive approval.” *Old Ben Coal*, 18 S.R.R. at 1093. “[I]f it is the considered judgment of the parties that whatever benefits might result from vindication of their positions would be outweighed by the costs of continued litigation and if the settlement otherwise complies with law the Commission authorizes the settlement.” *Delhi Petroleum Pty. Ltd. v. U.S. Atlantic & Gulf/Australia – New Zealand Conf. and Columbus Line, Inc.*, 24 S.R.R. 1129, 1134 (ALJ 1988) (citations omitted).

“Reaching a settlement allows the parties to settle their differences, without an admission of a violation of law by the respondent, when both the complainant and respondent have decided that it would be much cheaper to settle on such terms than to seek to prevail after expensive litigation.” *APM Terminals North America, Inc. v. Port Authority of New York and New Jersey*, 31 S.R.R. 623, 626 (FMC 2009) (citing *Puerto Rico Freight Sys. Inc. v. PR Logistics Corp.*, 30 S.R.R. 310, 311 (ALJ 2004)).

The parties state:

The Settlement Agreement negotiated by Greatway and ONE, with the advice and assistance of their respective counsel, is reasonable and not inconsistent with any law or policy. The Parties carefully considered the costs, benefits, and risks of further litigation, and determined that settlement is in their mutual interests. Similarly, the Settlement Agreement—an agreement between and negotiated by sophisticated business entities—was reached without fraud, duress, undue influence, or any other defect that would bar its approval. Moreover, BOE does not object to the settlement as a commercial resolution of this dispute. Accordingly, the Parties respectfully request that the Settlement Agreement be approved and that all of Greatway’s claims against ONE in the above-captioned proceeding be dismissed *with prejudice*.

Motion at 3.

BOE filed a response to the motion which states:

BOE is not a signatory to the settlement agreement between Greatway and ONE that has been submitted for the ALJ's approval. Although BOE initially participated in the settlement discussions, those discussions resulted in a commercial resolution which does not address BOE's concerns. BOE does not seek to interfere with the commercial resolution that the primary parties reached with assistance of counsel.

BOE Response at 3.

Based on the representations in the motion and other documents filed in this matter, the parties have established that the settlement agreement does not appear to violate any law or policy or contain other defects which might make it unapprovable. The parties are represented by counsel and have engaged in settlement discussions. The proceeding would require potentially expensive additional discovery and briefing. The parties have determined that the settlement reasonably resolves the issues raised in the complaint without the need for costly and uncertain litigation. Although BOE "continues to have concerns regarding whether ONE's application of its merchant clause may be a violation of the Shipping Act," BOE Response at 3, BOE does not oppose the settlement agreement and has not asserted any evidence of fraud, duress, undue influence, mistake, or harm to the public. Accordingly, the settlement agreement is approved.

The parties request that the settlement agreement be kept confidential. Pursuant to Commission Rule 5(b), parties may request confidentiality. 46 C.F.R. § 502.5(b); *see also* 46 C.F.R. § 502.141(j). "If parties wish to keep the terms of their settlement agreements confidential, the Commission, as well as the courts, have honored such requests." *Al Kogan v. World Express Shipping, Transportation and Forwarding Services, Inc.*, 29 S.R.R. 68, 70 n.7 (ALJ 2000) (citations omitted); *Marine Dynamics v. RTM Line, Ltd.*, 27 S.R.R. 503, 504 (ALJ 1996); *Int'l Assoc. of NVOCCs v. Atlantic Container Line*, 25 S.R.R. 1607, 1609 (ALJ 1991).

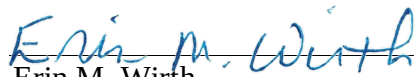
The full text of the settlement agreement has been reviewed by the undersigned and is available to the Commission. Given the parties' request for confidentiality, confidential information included in the settlement agreement, and the Commission's history of permitting agreements settling private complaints to remain confidential, the parties' request for confidentiality for the settlement agreement is granted. The settlement agreement will be maintained in the Secretary's confidential files.

Upon consideration of the motion, the settlement agreement, BOE's response, and the record, and good cause having been stated, it is hereby:

ORDERED that the motion to approve the settlement agreement between Greatway Logistics Group, LLC and Ocean Network Express Pte. Ltd. be **GRANTED**. It is

FURTHER ORDERED that the request for confidential treatment be **GRANTED**. It is

FURTHER ORDERED that this proceeding be **DISMISSED WITH PREJUDICE**.


Erin M. Wirth
Chief Administrative Law Judge